START-UP FEVER AT B-SCHOOLS

India's top B-schools are expanding the MBA playbook as students increasingly see entrepreneurship as another route to leadership

BY **PALAK AGARWAL**

PICTURE SECOND-YEAR MBA students in the middle of the placement season. Around them, classmates are preparing for consulting interviews, polishing case studies, and comparing compensation packages. The conventional B-school script is playing out as expected—land a good job, join a marquee company, and start climbing the corporate ladder.

But there is another conversation happening on the other side of the campus.

For a growing number of students, entrepreneurship is no longer a leap taken only after years in corporate India. The idea of building a company or, in today's parlance, a 'start-up' is entering the career conversation much earlier, sometimes even before the first job.

Students are not seeing a corporate role and entrepreneurship as opposing choices. For them, a stint in consulting can sharpen problem-solving, product management can teach customer and product thinking, finance can help evaluate businesses and capital, and a transformation role can teach how organisations change.

The choice is not entirely new. IIM Ahmedabad alumni Vineeta Singh and Kaushik Mukherjee turned down lucrative investment-banking offers to pursue entrepreneurship, while IIM Calcutta graduates Dharamveer Singh Chauhan and Paavan Nanda chose to build Zostel rather than follow the conventional corporate route. IIM Bangalore alumnus P. C. Mustafa, meanwhile, went on to build iD Fresh Food.

The numbers offer an evidence of the broader shift. The *BT*-MDRA survey found that the number of successful start-ups at top 25 B-schools increased 60% from the previous year. Those start-ups that have achieved sustainable revenue, market validation, and long-term viability are successful start-ups.

A separate GUESSS India survey of 13,896 higher-education students found that 14% intended to become entrepreneurs immediately after graduation; five years later, the figure rose to 31.4%.

MBA JOURNEY GETS REDEFINED

- **A corporate job is increasingly seen as one possible step towards entrepreneurship, rather than the final destination**
- **Incubators, founder programmes, investor networks, and alumni mentors are making entrepreneurship a more structured career option for students**
- **Some students arrive with entrepreneurial intent, while others discover it through peers, competitions, classroom discussions and exposure to founders**
- **Consulting, product, finance, and transformation roles build skills—problem-solving, product thinking, commercial judgement and capital evaluation—that can later be applied to building a company**
- **But the gap between aspiring entrepreneurs and those actually running revenue-generating businesses remains wide**